Evidence from elsewhere

Genocide and mass murder stem from a complex set of circumstances which collectively are used to legitimise violence against a specific group. Despite the claims of ethnic or religious ideologues, inter-group harmony is perfectly possible and in fact has been the norm for most of human history. Yes, group differences on the grounds of ethnicity or religious belief can and often do lead to tensions. And, if they are sufficiently serious and no higher authority intervenes, these tensions can often spill over into localised acts of violence. But in many cases, even when such local acts of violence flare up, they never produce something that could be defined as genocide. A good example comes from nearby northern India. This area sees regular acts of communal violence on religious grounds,[12] but these acts are highly localised. And even though there are quite a number of pockets of violence, other very similar areas nearby remain perfectly peaceful.[13]

One reason for this difference is the actions of local politicians. Thus Mumbai has seen regular violence, mostly stoked by politicians seeking to control the votes of particular ethnic groups, while Kolkata, which actually is even more mixed in terms of ethnicity and confessional communities, has rarely seen any ethnic or religious violence.[14] Of course, that's not all there is to the story. As Ashutosh Varshney argues, the difference is not just the malign actions of political leaders but the extent to which inter-communal interaction exists. Where society is organised so that different groups share many aspects of their communal life with each other (such as sports clubs, the educational system and access to the local state bureaucracy), it is hard to create the conditions for excessive violence. But where all these social and political institutions are also segregated (or one group is denied access) along political, ethnic or religious lines, it is easier to create the basis for inter-communal violence. In this respect, the exclusion of the Rohingyas from daily life in Rakhine is worrying, especially as fracturing the links between them and the Buddhist majority has become the deliberate policy of some extremist parties and is amplified by holding many Rohingyas within internal refugee camps.

Sustained ethnic or religious violence is hardly ever accidental, and even in situations where inter-ethnic distrust is common, it needs to be constructed by politicians and powerful groups who see it as a means to gain or retain power.[15] The shift to outright genocide in turn requires the